5
Growing Up in Army Cantonments

Life in the military cantonments in the 1950s was very different. I grew up in small towns or army cantonments like Patiala, Meerut, Babina (near Jhansi), Secunderabad and Jammu. Some of these places had no schools except for a few primary schools run by the government. The medium of education was Hindi or the regional languages. The army helped in the setting up of English-medium schools in many remote areas. Some of these were run by missionaries, and land and other facilities were made available to them. I recall the dedication and sincere commitment of the Portuguese and Goan fathers who taught us in St Francis Xavier School in Babina in the early 1950s.

In two places, the schools I went to happened to be convents meant to provide education to girls. These were St Anne's Convent in Bolarum, Secunderabad, and St Mary's Presentation Convent in Jammu. Wards of military personnel, including boys, as special and exceptional cases, were readily given admissions in these schools. Quite unlike the case today, we sometimes even got 'double promotions' based on our performance. I was quite good at studies and also had a decent handwriting. The question of any extra tuition or coaching never arose.

In some of these quaint little places, life was adventurous, easy-paced and rustic. There were very few amenities or avenues for entertainment, other than what was available in the cantonments. There were no malls, multiplex cinemas, TV, music systems or mobile telephones. Even ordinary phones were the status symbols of important people – I had seen none till I entered my teens! Those were the days of the gramophone, and even that was rare.